A HISTORICAL MUSIC DRAMA / LIVE-ACTION CONCERT FILM

LIVE AT LEEDS

The Who - February 1970

FEATURE FILM / PRODUCTION SPECIFICATION

PROPOSED PRODUCTION BUDGET **£35,000,000**

Proposed running time: 130-145 minutes | Format: 4K digital cinema | Country: United Kingdom

ONE NIGHT. ONE BAND. ONE LEGENDARY RECORDING.

Development brief | 30 October 2026

A proposed cinematic reconstruction of the events surrounding The Who's landmark Leeds performance of 14 February 1970. This document is a development concept, not an authorised production or a statement that music, archive, name or likeness rights have been secured.



PROJECT OVERVIEW

01 Film concept

A premium British music film that combines historical drama, full-scale period reconstruction and an immersive recreation of The Who on stage.

Logline. In February 1970, The Who set out to capture the force of their live performance on record. Over a week of preparations, technical improvisation and band dynamics, the story builds towards the group's celebrated performance at Leeds University Refectory - and the recording that became Live at Leeds.

The film is designed as a live-action feature rather than a conventional documentary or a modern tribute concert. It brings the audience into the rooms, streets, backstage spaces and recording environment surrounding the Leeds show, before opening out into an extended concert sequence.

THE CINEMATIC PROMISE
Make the audience feel that they have travelled back to Leeds in February 1970 and are standing inside the Refectory, watching The Who perform.

THE FORM
Historical music drama with concert-film scale. The narrative establishes the people and practical circumstances; the music delivers the emotional climax.

Project at a glance

FORMAT	SETTING	BUDGET	RUNNING TIME
Live-action feature film	Leeds / Hull, February 1970	£35.0m production budget	130-145 minutes (target)
IMAGE	**SOUND**	**GENRE**	**RELEASE**
4K digital cinema / 2.39:1	Dolby Atmos, 5.1 and stereo	Historical music drama / concert film	International theatrical ambition

Historical foundation

The Who performed at Leeds University Refectory on 14 February 1970. Their official discography describes the album as recorded on Valentine's Day and released in the UK in May 1970. The original LP contained six tracks; later editions expanded the release to include the full Leeds performance, including the complete Tommy sequence. The 40th-anniversary set also documents the band's Hull City Hall performance on 15 February 1970.

The film may use the week as a dramatic frame, but any scene-specific chronology, private conversation or backstage incident must be checked against research and clearly treated as dramatised where the record is incomplete.

DRAMATIC STRUCTURE

02 Narrative architecture

A seven-day framework supplies a natural build to the concert, while keeping the difference between documented history and dramatic invention visible.

PERIOD	STORY FUNCTION	SCREEN MATERIAL
9-11 February	**Set-up**	Introduce the band, the live-album ambition and the practical problem of capturing a performance with the immediacy of the stage. Rehearsal and travel scenes may be used as dramatic connective material.
12-13 February	**Preparation**	Recording logistics, equipment, venue preparation, university atmosphere and the road crew. Establish the Refectory as an intimate, working venue rather than a modern arena.
14 February	**Leeds performance**	The principal concert sequence: load-in, sound check, recording operation, audience arrival and the full performance.
15 February	**Hull coda**	A short concluding movement around the Hull City Hall performance, illustrating that Leeds was part of a two-night recording plan.

Three-act shape

ACT I - THE PROBLEM The band, the live-album ambition and the limits of existing recordings. Character relationships are established through rehearsal, discussion and the practicalities of touring.	ACT II - THE BUILD The journey into Leeds, the Refectory, the crew and the recording set-up. The pressure is practical and musical: the band must deliver a performance worth capturing.	ACT III - THE EVENT A sustained, increasingly immersive concert sequence. The Hull performance provides a brief coda, while the audience understands the significance of the Leeds recording in retrospect.

Historical treatment and safeguards

- Documented anchors: the Leeds show on 14 February 1970, the Hull City Hall show on 15 February, the original album and the later complete-show releases.
- Dramatised connective scenes: conversations, private disagreements, travel details and day-by-day activities should be labelled in production research as verified, inferred or invented.
- Research process: consult the band, surviving crew and engineers where available; check venue archives, photographs, press reports, recording documentation and release notes.
- Authenticity rule: do not invent quotations and present them as verbatim historical statements.

The exact itinerary for 9-13 February is a proposed screenplay structure, not a claim that every listed preparation is independently documented on those dates.

PERFORMANCE-LED CASTING

03 Principal characters and casting

The four musicians are the dramatic and musical centre of the production. Casting should favour instrument and vocal ability over celebrity resemblance alone.

CHARACTER	ON-STAGE ROLE	PERFORMANCE REQUIREMENT
Pete Townshend	Guitar / vocals	Convincing guitar work, physical stage language, rhythmic drive and the restless creative energy of the band's principal songwriter.
Roger Daltrey	Lead vocals	Vocal power, breath control, audience engagement and a credible physical presence as frontman.
John Entwistle	Bass / vocals	Technical bass performance, timing and a controlled, understated stage presence.
Keith Moon	Drums / vocals	High-level drumming, stamina, physical energy and comic unpredictability without reducing the character to caricature.

Casting and rehearsal protocol

- Audition for musical competence and acting ability together; use live ensemble tests before final casting.
- Provide an intensive band rehearsal period, with the actors learning the arrangements and playing as a unit.
- Use specialist doubles only where a technically demanding close-up or safety requirement makes them necessary; maintain continuity between actor performance and camera coverage.
- Build a shared understanding of each musician's stage habits, instrument handling, posture, timing and interactions.
- Consult archival photographs, interviews, performance footage and surviving associates; distinguish imitation from character interpretation.

Supporting roles

The supporting ensemble should include recording engineers, road crew, management, university organisers, venue staff, students and local residents. Where an identifiable historical individual is depicted, the portrayal should be researched and cleared. Composite characters may be used where the historical record is incomplete, with care not to attribute invented conduct to a real person.

The film should show the band as a working group under pressure: funny, forceful, occasionally difficult and musically interdependent. Avoid simple hero worship or retrospective dialogue that makes the participants seem aware of the album's future reputation.

THE PRINCIPAL CINEMATIC EVENT

04 Concert production

The Leeds performance is the centrepiece. It should be staged as a live event captured by a film crew, not as a conventional sequence of clean, isolated music-video shots.

The Refectory

Build or adapt a full-scale period-accurate recreation of Leeds University Refectory. The space should support a convincing stage, audience floor, backstage routes, technical positions and a visible relationship between performers and crowd. Audience density should be based on venue research and the best available evidence, rather than an assumed modern capacity.

- Period stage layout, lighting, PA, microphones, stands, cables and instrument amplification.
- Accurate instrument models and period-correct guitar, bass, drum and amplifier configurations.
- A practical backstage and load-in environment that can sustain long concert takes.
- Audience extras trained in period movement, dress, crowd behaviour and the conventions of a 1970 university rock show.
- A recreation of the recording operation positioned in the Refectory kitchen, as described in The Who's official anniversary-edition notes.

Camera language

UNIT	FUNCTION	VISUAL APPROACH
A - stage master	Band geography	Stable wide and medium coverage that preserves the four musicians' physical relationship.
B - audience	Immersion	Eye-level handheld and shoulder-height movement from within the crowd.
C - instrument	Musicianship	Close details of Townshend's guitar, Entwistle's bass, Moon's drums and Daltrey's vocal performance.
D - roaming	Documentary texture	Backstage passages, stage edges and spontaneous reactions; movement should feel motivated, not ornamental.
E - control room	Recording story	Engineers monitoring levels and tape, giving the audience a second perspective on the event being captured.

Concert sequence design

Target 35-45 minutes of substantially continuous concert experience, distributed through the final act and supported by short musical passages earlier in the film. The editing should retain the sense of duration, volume and audience proximity. Cuts should follow musical and dramatic logic; avoid excessively polished music-video grammar.

Practical execution

Use controlled live performance capture with isolated multitrack recording, playback or guide tracks as appropriate, while preserving the visible physicality of the actors playing. Record audience responses separately and as live wild tracks. Keep a concert continuity bible for instrument positions, microphone angles, cable paths, sweat, costume wear and performance energy.

THE LEEDS PERFORMANCE

05 Music and sound

The music must feel immediate and slightly unruly. The production should preserve the raw character of the original event while delivering a clear, powerful theatrical mix.

Working musical programme

The following cue list reflects the expanded documentation of the Leeds performance, including the complete Tommy sequence. The 40th-anniversary edition separates the material across discs; final film order, transitions and any omissions should be checked against the best available concert recordings and archival documentation.

01 Heaven and Hell	18 Pinball Wizard
02 I Can't Explain	19 Do You Think It's Alright?
03 Fortune Teller	20 Fiddle About
04 Tattoo	21 Tommy, Can You Hear Me?
05 Young Man Blues	22 There's a Doctor
06 Substitute	23 Go to the Mirror!
07 Happy Jack	24 Smash the Mirror
08 I'm a Boy	25 Miracle Cure
09 A Quick One, While He's Away	26 Sally Simpson
10 Overture	27 I'm Free
11 It's a Boy	28 Tommy's Holiday Camp
12 1921	29 We're Not Gonna Take It
13 Amazing Journey	30 Summertime Blues
14 Sparks	31 Shakin' All Over
15 Eyesight to the Blind	32 My Generation
16 Christmas	33 Magic Bus
17 The Acid Queen	

Sound design and recording philosophy

- Performance first: prioritise credible playing, strong vocal delivery and a coherent band sound.
- Period character: recreate the attack, room sound, amplifier response and analogue recording texture without turning the soundtrack into a novelty filter.
- Audience as an instrument: capture crowd noise, movement, shouts and room response as part of the performance.
- Cinematic mix: create Dolby Atmos, 5.1 and stereo versions, with intelligible vocals and a wide dynamic range.
- Music supervision: obtain composition, publishing, master-use and any necessary arrangement permissions; the rights allowance is subject to negotiation.

The original six-track LP is a separate cultural reference point: Young Man Blues, Substitute, Summertime Blues, Shakin' All Over, My Generation and Magic Bus. The feature should understand the difference between the original album sequence and the later expanded documentation of the concert.

IMAGE AND PRODUCTION DESIGN

06 Visual direction and technical specification

A grounded, recognisably British early-1970s world. The film should favour texture, lived-in locations and practical environments over nostalgic decoration.

Visual approach

- Leeds as a character: winter streets, university buildings, student accommodation, pubs, shops, transport and the industrial atmosphere of West Yorkshire.
- Period realism: researched signage, vehicles, furniture, clothing, hair, printed matter, stage equipment and backstage clutter.
- Camera: intimate handheld movement for people and performance, balanced with composed wides that establish the venue and band geometry.
- Colour: restrained period-informed palette, tactile blacks and warm practical light; avoid artificial sepia or constant retro filters.
- Effects: limited to invisible environmental extensions, crowd support and period clean-up. Practical sets and physical performance are the priority.

Technical delivery

ELEMENT	TARGET SPECIFICATION
Acquisition	4K digital cinema capture; 24 fps base frame rate; selective high-speed capture only where editorially justified.
Presentation	2.39:1 widescreen theatrical master. Consider premium large-format exhibition where the final image and mix justify it.
Sound	Multitrack performance capture; Dolby Atmos theatrical mix, plus 5.1 and stereo deliverables.
Lighting	Period-inspired practicals and stage lighting, designed for safe, repeatable concert coverage.
Post-production	Picture edit, conform, colour grade, VFX clean-up, music edit, dialogue edit, final mix, mastering and QC.
Accessibility	Subtitles, captions, audio description and accessible deliverables as required by distribution partners.

Production design research pack

Before final design sign-off, compile reference boards for the Refectory, stage layout, kitchen recording position, instruments and amplifiers, wardrobe, street dressing, student interiors and the February weather. Each major item should carry a provenance note: archival photograph, surviving object, catalogue reference, oral history or informed reconstruction.

£35 MILLION ALLOCATION

07 Production budget

Indicative top-sheet for development planning. Figures are allowances, not quotations or confirmed commitments.

DEPARTMENT	BUDGET (£m)
Development and historical research	0.8
Music, publishing, master-use and likeness rights allowance	5.0
Principal cast and performance ensemble	3.5
Director, producers and screenwriters	2.0
Production crew and management	4.7
Sets, locations and period reconstruction	3.7
Wardrobe, hair, make-up and props	1.4
Concert stage, PA, instruments and recording equipment	2.0
Musical rehearsals and performance capture	1.2
Audience casting and extras	1.0
Transport, accommodation, insurance and logistics	1.5
Picture editing, post-production, colour and VFX	2.0
Sound post-production, music mixing and mastering	2.0
Delivery and accessibility	0.5
Production contingency	3.7
TOTAL PRODUCTION BUDGET	**35.0**

Budget priorities

- Rights: clear compositions, publishing, master recordings where used, name and likeness, archive footage, photographs and artwork. The £5.0m line is a planning allowance only; availability and final price are unknown.
- Concert reconstruction: protect the Refectory build, audience, instruments, PA and extended performance photography from late-stage reductions.
- Musical preparation: ring-fence enough rehearsal and capture time to make the actors' performances credible.
- Contingency: retain the £3.7m reserve for rights variance, period-build complexity, schedule pressure and post-production changes.

Scope note: the £35m is the proposed production budget. Marketing, publicity, distribution fees, financing costs and any sales-agent commission are not separately included unless later folded into a revised financing plan.

EXECUTION PLAN

08 Schedule, release and delivery

A rights-led development process followed by a concentrated period of ensemble preparation, concert photography and music-intensive post-production.

PHASE	PLANNING WINDOW	KEY OUTPUT
Development / research	12 weeks	Historical research bible, screenplay treatment, location strategy and preliminary budget.
Rights negotiations	6-12 months; overlapping	Music, publishing, master-use, name/likeness, archive and artwork permissions.
Casting	10 weeks	Principal cast and supporting ensemble; musical auditions.
Musical preparation	16 weeks	Band rehearsal, instrument training, arrangement and performance tests.
Production preparation	16-20 weeks	Sets, period research, Refectory build, locations, wardrobe and technical rehearsals.
Principal photography	8-10 weeks	Drama and concert capture, with extended time allocated to the performance.
Post-production	Approx. 6-8 months	Picture edit, music edit, sound mix, colour, VFX, mastering and QC.

Distribution proposition

- Primary: international theatrical release, with a premium event-cinema window and selected large-format engagements where technically suitable.
- Secondary: premium streaming after the theatrical window, subject to distributor strategy.
- Collector edition: 4K UHD and vinyl soundtrack, subject to music rights and availability.
- Ancillary: production book, archival featurettes, interviews, rehearsal material and a behind-the-scenes documentary.

Artistic objectives

The production should deliver historical authenticity, convincing musical performance, true concert immersion, a strong sense of Leeds as a place and a lasting cinematic interpretation of an important moment in British popular music. The guiding principle is to recreate the experience, not merely the appearance, of The Who at Leeds in 1970.

Rights, approvals and historical research

This is a proposed, unauthorised development concept. No rights, clearances, access, participant approvals or production commitments are implied. A production of this kind requires formal music and publishing licences, name and likeness clearances, archive permissions, location permissions and appropriate legal review. The budget is a planning model and should be stress-tested with rights holders, insurers, financiers and production counsel.

Selected historical references

The Who, “Live At Leeds” official discography page - release history and original six-track LP. thewho.com/music/live-at-leeds

The Who, “Live at Leeds 40th Anniversary Super-Deluxe Collectors’ Edition” - expanded Leeds and Hull track listings; notes that the mobile recording unit was placed in the university refectory kitchen. thewho.com - 40th anniversary edition

Whotabs, “The Who at Leeds University Refectory, 14 February 1970” - supplementary equipment and recording research. thewho.net/whotabs